

LIVE



NEWSPAPER

EDITORIALS

25th Apr, 2017

2/17th WEEK

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1

The best laid plans

NITI Aayog's shift away from five-year plans requires more substance

Narendra Modi is not the first Chief Minister to have gone on to become Prime Minister. But given his well-known disdain for the erstwhile Planning Commission's control-and-command approach towards States and his oft-repeated emphasis on 'cooperative federalism', there were great expectations from the successor organisation, the NITI Aayog. The Five Year Plans – the last one ended on March 31 – were relegated to history, to be replaced by a three-year action plan. This was to be part of a seven-year strategy that would in turn help realise a 15-year long-term vision. When the Aayog's Governing Council that includes the Prime Minister and all Chief Ministers met, it was hoped that the fine print as well as the big picture of the new planning approach had been worked out. However, all that was handed out was a draft action agenda for the three years till 2019-20, with 300 specific action points. This agenda is meant to be the first step towards attaining the envisioned outcomes by 2031-32. This 'New India', as NITI Aayog Vice Chairman Arvind Panagariya put it, will ensure housing for all, with toilets, LPG, power and digital connections; access to a personal vehicle, air conditioner and white goods for 'nearly all'; and a fully literate population with universal health care.

Assuming that the economy grows at 8% annually hereon, the Aayog has presented estimates about the size of the economy and per capita incomes by 2031-32, though juxtaposing these with China's performance in the last 15 years is a bit odd. India's GDP will rise by ₹332

THE  HINDU

Date : 25th April, 2017

NITI Aayog



सत्यमेव जयते

नीति आयोग

National Institution for Transforming India

SALIENT INFORMATION

- 1 Chairperson is the Hon'ble Prime Minister.
- 2 It is the premier policy 'Think Tank' of the GOI, providing both directional and policy inputs.
- 3 It replaced 65-year old Planning Commission and is an executive body.
- 4 It is also vested with the responsibility of putting 17 Sustainable Development Goals into action and monitor their implementation, over the next 15 years.
- 5 It also focus on technology upgradation and capacity building for implementation of programmes & initiatives.

NITI Aayog

NITI Aayog

National Institution for Transforming India



- Co-operative federalism
- Think Tank of the Govt.
- Bottom-up approach
- Formulate policies at village level and scale them up.

NEWS REPORT

1 NITI Aayog replaced Planning Commission.

2 The mantra is cooperative federalism.

3 The five year plans became history.

4 The present strategy of NITI Aayog is to have three year action plan, seven year strategy along with realising 15 year long term perspective plan.

5 Governing Council, which include Prime Minister and the Chief Ministers met recently.

6 A draft action agenda for three years till 2019-20, with 300 specific points was handed over.

7 The agenda is meant to be the first step towards attaining the envisioned outcomes by 2031-32.

IMPORTANT POINTS OF NEW INDIA AGENDA



नीति आयोग
National Institution for Transforming India



Shri Narendra Modi
Chairman, Niti Aayog

- 1 Housing for all with toilets.
- 2 Universal LPG, power and digital connections.
- 3 Access to a personal vehicle, Air Conditioner and white goods for 'nearly all'.
- 4 Fully literate population with universal healthcare.

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WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE?

1

The fifteen year Perspective Plan, must include goals and strategies to be adopted and the Government must start working from that 15 year Perspective Plan into three year action agenda.

2

For the past two years and four months, the success story of cooperative federalism is GST and similar efforts must be made to overhaul sectors like education, health and skill development in a mission mode.

3

Infrastructure spending is one area and the Prime Minister called upon the states to enhance infrastructure spending, but most of the states are not in a position to do so and Centre should push aggressively to enhance the infrastructure spending.

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WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE?

4

“Bharatmala” should be implemented in a mission mode, which envisages road infrastructure, connecting ports as well as development of economic corridors.

5

Government knows very well that 12th Plan ends on 31st March, 2017. Why there is not much action for the past two years with regard to 15 year Perspective Plan is not understood.

6

Though the intentions of NITI Aayog are good, but at ground level they are not getting reflected.

2

A stark choice

French voters assert their anti-establishment mood in the first round of presidential polls

1

The French follow their hearts in the first round, and their heads in the run-off – or so goes the cliché about France's politics. But the first round of this year's presidential election was held in such a highly charged environment that voters did not have easy choices before them. And the outcome was unusual, though not totally unexpected. For the first time in the nearly 59 years of France's Fifth Republic founded by Charles de Gaulle, neither of the mainstream left and right parties made it to the run-off, a clear indication of anti-establishment sentiment running high. All these years, France has been ruled either by a Socialist party leader or a conservative Republican. In the May 7 run-off, the fight is between Emmanuel Macron, an independent centrist with no substantial political experience, and Marine Le Pen, the far-right populist leader of the National Front. Mr. Macron, who campaigned on a pro-Europe political platform with promises of economic reforms and better governance, won 23.75% of the vote, while Ms. Le Pen, who during the campaign repeatedly attacked the EU, globalisation and France's immigration policies to drum up support, came second, polling 21.53%. François Fillon of the Republican party finished third, while Benoît Hamon of the ruling Socialist Party came a distant fifth.

Opinion polls predict that Mr. Macron will win the second round as a majority of voters regard Ms. Le Pen and her party as dangerous for France's democracy and its values. This is not the first time a National Front can-

2

And now there are two

This French presidential election has exposed dangerous fault lines in the country's politics:



EMILE CHABAL

Elections are generally about the winners. But the first round of the French presidential election on Sunday was as much about the losers as it was about the two figures who reached the run-off, Emmanuel Macron and Marine Le Pen.

By far the biggest losers in this election were the two traditional parties of government. On the centre-right, François Fillon continued to lose an election that seemed to have been tailor-made for him. François Hollande's devastating approval ratings in the final year of his presidency – polls suggested that fewer than 5% of French electors were 'satisfied' with his performance – made a right-wing victory almost a certainty. All Mr. Fillon had to do was reach the second round of the presidential election and he was guaranteed to win.

Fillon's flip

Instead, he committed political suicide. His corrupt past caught up with him and he hemorrhaged votes to Mr. Macron. His failure to reach even the 20% in the first round, despite strong mobilisation amongst his core electorate, sealed his fate. This is the first time under the Fifth Republic that the right has not had a candidate in a presidential run-off. It will be a defining trauma for future generations of right-wing activists.

Not that the centre-left has much to cheer. The socialist candidate, Benoît Hamon, was all but obliterated. His score of 6.3% was the worst for a centre-left candidate since 1969. Mr. Hamon offered a raft of new and exciting policy ideas, but he rapidly lost momentum. In any case, French presidential elections are never won with good ideas, and he did not have the charisma to carve out a space for himself.

So, where Sunday night was a catastrophe for the party institutions of the French left, it was more positive for millions of left-wing voters who cast their ballots for the maverick far-left candidate Jean-Luc Mélenchon. His score of 19.4% exceeded all expectations. Across southern and western France, traditional socialist bastions voted for Mr. Mélenchon, in



Face-off: "Marine Le Pen is the voice of a poorer, disenfranchised peripheral France, while Emmanuel Macron is the candidate of affluent, cosmopolitan France." Campaign posters of Ms. Le Pen and Mr. Macron in Lyon, France. > 400

part to protest against five years of left-wing 'compromise' under Mr. Hollande, in part simply because the far-left candidate ran a highly persuasive campaign.

The problem, of course, is that Mr. Mélenchon is a one-man show. He is supported by the French Communist Party, but he is independent of it. And it is not clear whether he can pull together a far-left coalition for the upcoming parliamentary elections. The future of the French left will depend on the ability of the socialists to maintain their strong local representation, as well as absorb the discontent that led so many of their supporters to vote for a candidate whose sole aim is to destroy the Socialist Party.

Uncertain victories

And what of the two winners? Here, too, the picture is more ambiguous than the triumphant rhetoric would suggest. Ms. Le Pen achieved a respectable 21.53% but this is far below the inflated expectations of her supporters (and her detractors). Over the past three months, her poll ratings declined inexorably – from 28% to 22% – and her campaign exposed all of her ideological and institutional weaknesses. Despite a discredited

left-wing government and a climate of insecurity, she only managed a modest increase in her vote share compared to 2012.

The French are right to feel immense shame and deep concern that a far-right candidate has once again reached the second round of a presidential election, but it is fairly clear that if Mr. Fillon had run a better campaign, Ms. Le Pen would have been eliminated. She has secured her support base in northern and south-eastern France, but there is almost no chance of her winning the run-off. The only question is how badly she will lose. If she manages 25%, it will be a humiliation; if she manages 40%, she can claim a pyrrhic victory.

For Mr. Macron, on the other hand, the news is mostly good. His score of 23.75% and the fact that he came in first place give him enormous legitimacy going into the run-off. Mr. Fillon and Mr. Hamon have already called on their supporters to vote for him, and while Mr. Mélenchon has so far refused to do so, there is little doubt that a vast majority of his supporters will prefer to cast their votes for a shiny technocrat rather than a crypto-fascist.

Yet even here there is cause for concern: insofar as Mr. Macron is a

known quantity, he is seen as the architect of Mr. Hollande's unpopular economic policies, and there is little evidence at this stage that his presidency will deviate significantly from that of his predecessor. Just as crucial is the question of who will govern. Who will be his Prime Minister? How will he build a 'non-partisan' party? In many ways, the run-off in two weeks' time has now become much less important than the parliamentary elections in June. These will determine the balance of power for the next five years.

More fundamentally, this election has exposed dangerous fault lines in French politics. For it is quite clear that Mr. Macron is the candidate of affluent, cosmopolitan France, while Ms. Le Pen is the voice of a poorer, disenfranchised peripheral France. Rarely has this long-standing distinction been so starkly reflected in a French election. If Mr. Macron does not find a way to deal with this issue, the real losers of Sunday's vote will be the French people.

Emile Chabal is a Chancellor's Fellow at the University of Edinburgh and the author of *A Divided Republic: Nation, State and Citizenship in Contemporary France*. E-mail: emile.chabal@ed.ac.uk

FRENCH ELECTION ... 1st ROUND



EMMANUEL MACRON
EN MARCHÉ PARTY

24%



MARINE LE PEN
NATIONAL FRONT PARTY

21.3%



FRANÇOIS FILLON
REPUBLICAN PARTY

20%



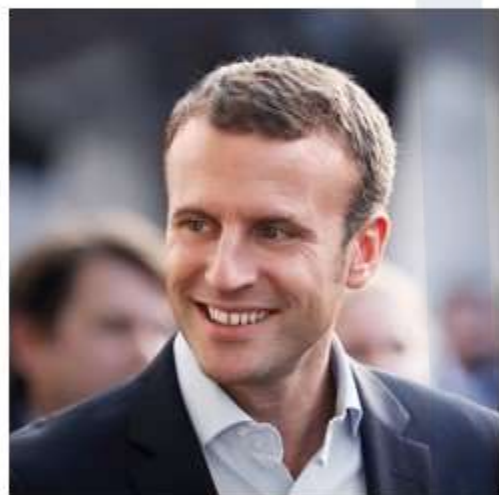
JEAN-LUC MÉLENCHON
LA FRANCE INSOUMISE.

19.6%

The top 2 contenders will go for 2nd round of polling, which is going to take place on 7th May



PROMISES BY EMMANUEL MACRON



EMMANUEL MACRON
EN MARCHE PARTY

- 1** Cut 1,20,000 public sector jobs and bring down the budget deficit. Cut public spending by € 60 bn in 5 years.
- 2** A € 50 bn public investment plan to cover job-training, and shift to renewable energy
- 3** Slash corporation tax from 33% to 25%
- 4** Bring down unemployment from 10% to 7%.
- 5** Unify the pension system
- 6** Bolster EU ties and the Eurozone, higher tariffs to protect European industry
- 7** Common border force

MARINE LE PEN ... CAMPAIGN PROMISES



MARINE LE PEN
NATIONAL FRONT PARTY

- 1** Automatic expulsion of illegal immigrants and legal immigration cut to 10,000 per year from 2,00,000.
- 2** Abandon the Euro and return to Franc
- 3** Renegotiate France's EU membership
- 4** Supports referendum on leaving EU and the Eurozone
- 5** Lowering Retirement age to 60 years
- 6** 35-hour week assured
- 7** Bans wearing of ostentatious religious symbols such as Muslim head-scarves and veils in public
- 8** Priority to French nationals in social housing

3

The climate fight is global

The Paris accord requires vigilance by all global actors in view of the U.S.'s changed stance on climate change



SUJATHA BYRAVAN

Farmers from Tamil Nadu were gathered in Delhi recently, carrying skulls, apparently belonging to those among them who had committed suicide. They were seeking government assistance following the worst drought in the State in recent times. Concurrently, there are several droughts in many other parts of the world, including Bolivia and several regions of Sub-Saharan Africa. Scorched lands have led to dying livestock, withering crops, and parched communities.

Several recent extreme events such as wildfires, droughts, severe heatwaves and cyclones in other places have a clear signature of a changing climate, but in many cases these are exacerbated by other institutional failures. None of this has, however, persuaded the present U.S. government that anthropogenic greenhouse gases (GHGs) are responsible for climate change. The U.S. is still the world's second largest annual emitter of GHGs and has generated more than a quarter of the total anthropogenic GHGs in the atmosphere since 1850.

Even though the U.S. has not technically withdrawn from the Paris Agreement from last December, when countries came together and set climate-related targets for themselves, President Donald Trump's recent decisions are a sweeping repudiation of former U.S. President Barack Obama's policies to reduce and limit pollution and GHGs.

The curbs on power plant emissions by the Obama administration – the Clean Power Plan (CPP) – were aimed at reducing the power sector's carbon dioxide emissions by about a third below the 2005 levels by 2030. The regulations would require states and electric utilities to reduce emissions either by deploying renewables, reducing demand or increasing power plant efficiencies.

Effect of Trump's actions

Mr. Trump's orders not only directed federal agencies to cancel or amend policies that might interfere with domestic energy production, but also slashed research budgets for climate change.

In any case, the Environmental Protection Agency's (EPA) CPP has been in the courts for more than a year due to a legal challenge mounted by over half the U.S. states and a number of companies that opposed the rule. Nevertheless, even if Mr. Trump's order to eliminate the CPP were to go into effect, his adminis-



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK PHOTO

tration is required by a 2007 U.S. Supreme Court ruling to regulate carbon dioxide. Moreover, the EPA's rules are themselves not easy to reverse by a stroke of the presidential pen, especially given another 2009 EPA finding that GHGs "threaten the public health and welfare of current and future generations".

How far Mr. Trump will continue to push for curbs on climate change reduction in the U.S. and any possible ripple effects from these remain to be seen. Under the circumstances, most commentators believe that his actions will have a limited impact.

Still, the recent moves by its President are a clear signal that the U.S. is no longer interested in curbing GHGs to stabilise the climate and neither is it keen to meet its Paris commitments.

Mr. Trump's actions also demonstrate that allowing countries to write their own Nationally Deter-

mined Contributions, seen as an improvement to a global top-down approach, still has to confront the same political problem – continued implementation of the agreement by successive governments within each country. That a major emitter is retreating from its former commitments is of course a danger to the world's climate, but this may not be a big step back if other countries persist with their efforts and if renewables continue to get more affordable as they have recently. This move also provides elbow room for renewable energy businesses elsewhere to pick up the slack in interest within the U.S.

Nonetheless, it does make one wonder how the U.S. or Europe would have responded if another country, say, India, had undertaken similar actions. There may have been little time lost before name-calling and shaming began, following which global trade sanctions would likely have been imposed, or perhaps other kinds of bans or penalties. The chance that any of this will happen now towards the U.S., still a superpower, appears to be slim.

Role of sub-national actors

Nation states are the proper agencies responsible for curbing emissions to the shared global commons. Nevertheless, Mr. Trump's recalcitrance shows that a change in political leadership could lead to

the backing out of an international treaty by any signatory. Global agreements are often tenuous and need support and pressure from other actors within and across countries who function at many levels: states, territories or provinces within a country, cities, policy think tanks, scientists, philanthropists, local communities, civil society organisations, investors, transnational groups and multinational industries.

For example, the now global movement created by 350.org and other climate protection advocacy groups in Europe and elsewhere has made impressive progress on many fronts. The regional commitments to reducing GHGs by states in large parts of the U.S., the philanthropies that are supporting improvements in efficiencies and innovations in the climate and energy sector, and cities such as New York and Seattle, which are committed to building a low-carbon future, are all examples of sub-national entities that have a powerful influence. Thus, whether it is Mr. Trump or a Democrat in the White House, the work for these players is quite important. Climate change, like democracy itself, requires vigilance and participation by both state and non-state actors.

Sujatha Byravan is Principal Research Scientist, Center for Study of Science, Technology & Policy, Bengaluru

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GROUND REALITY IN THE WORLD

- 1 There are several severe droughts in many parts of the world, including Bolivia and several regions of Sub-Saharan Africa.
- 2 Scorched lands have led to dying livestock, withering crops, and parched communities.
- 3 One of the worst droughts in Tamil Nadu is a case in point.
- 4 Several recent extreme events such as wildfires, droughts, severe heatwaves and cyclones in other places have a clear signature of a changed climate.

3 The climate fight is global

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CASE OF THE USA

1

The U.S. is still the world's second largest annual emitter of GHGs.

2

It has generated more than a quarter of the total anthropogenic GHGs in the atmosphere since 1850.

The basic point here is Donald Trump's actions are in repudiation of the policies formulated by former U.S. President Barack Obama.

DONALD TRUMP AND ACTIONS IN THE USA

- 1 The Obama administration brought the Clean Power Plan (CPP) aimed at reducing the power sector's carbon dioxide emissions by about a third below the 2005 levels by 2030.
 - 2 The regulations would require states and electric utilities to reduce emissions either by **switching over to renewables, reducing demand or increasing power plant efficiencies**.
 - 3 Donald Trump's administration **slashed** research budgets for climate change and directed federal agencies to **cancel or amend policies** that might interfere with domestic energy production.
 - 4 After the CPP by Obama, over half the U.S. states and a number of companies that opposed CPP went to Court.
 - 5 Moreover, in 2007 U.S. Supreme Court ruled to regulate carbon dioxide.
 - 6 Another EPA finding in 2009 said that GHGs threaten the public health and welfare of current and future generations.
- It appears that the U.S. is no longer interested in curbing GHGs to stabilise the climate and also it is not keen to meet its Paris commitments.***

UNANSWERED QUESTIONS

- 1 How can a country can back track from an international treaty so easily? If such type of withdrawal is done by a country like India, can the developed world remain silent?
- 2 If an international treaty can be vitiated like this, then, where is the end and what is the sanctity of such treaties?
- 3 The Paris treaty is not a top-down approach, but it is based on the commitments given by the countries in the form of Nationally Determined Contributions and hence, implementation by each country, depends on will power of the countries.
- 4 Global agreements need support and pressure from other actors within and across countries, who function at several levels, which include policy think-tanks, scientists, philanthropists, local communities etc.

Under these circumstances, what will happen to the low-carbon future?

4 The appeasement of none

We must move beyond the minority-majority binary



GOPAL KRISHNA AGARWAL

Communal politics, which ironically passes for secularism in this country, has been the bane of Indian politics. It can be traced back to the British policy of 'divide and rule', the result of which was Partition. The Constitution was a repudiation of these ideas and the politics that perpetuated them. It rejected the suggestions for a separate electorate for the minorities and the proportional representation system, which it felt would lead to a perpetually enervated nation. But in most policies that have been followed until now, we have seen furtherance of vote-bank politics. The narrative has to change.

The recent PIL filed by a Jammu-based advocate, Ankur Sharma, in the Supreme Court, alleging that the rights of religious and linguistic minorities in the State are being "siphoned off illegally and arbitrarily" and the subsequent affidavits by the Central and Jammu and Kashmir governments give us a chance to look again into the secularism versus communalism debate.

Defining minority

While Articles 29 and 30 of the Constitution guarantee certain rights to minorities for protection of their culture, script, and languages, the Constitution has not defined or identified religious and linguistic minorities. The question of who will determine which group is a minority was also left unanswered until the Supreme Court settled this in *TMA Pai Foundation v. State of Karnataka*,

Hindus are a religious minority in seven States (Arunachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Punjab) and in one UT (Lakshadweep). In J&K, Hindus have been at the receiving end of majoritarian wrath, and the constitutional guarantee of liberty of thought, expression, belief, faith and worship is being violated there. The status of West Pakistan refugees, who had migrated there at the time of Partition, is also relevant. Reports suggest that there are about 2.5 lakh Hindus. They are not recognised as state subjects and are denied the most basic human rights.

Though the Act nowhere makes it mandatory for States to have a Minorities Commission of their own, 18 do. However, the question is whether minorities get the benefits of being so in all the States where they are in minority. In Punjab, for instance, Hindus are only 38.4% of the population, but they have not been notified as a minority in the Punjab State Commission for Minorities Act, 2012. Is it not amoral to insist on special dispensation for minorities and deny Hindus minority status where they are entitled to it, as is being done by various political parties?



Furthering vote-bank politics

Further, the SC in *Bal Patil v. Union of India* had said the National and State Minorities Commissions should direct their activities to maintain the unity and integrity of India by

THE  HINDU

Date : 25th April, 2017



WHAT DO YOU UNDERSTAND BY MINORITY STATUS?

ARTICLE 29

29. Protection of interests of minorities
(1) Any section of the citizens residing in the territory of India or any part thereof having a distinct language, script or culture of its own shall have the right to conserve the same

ARTICLE 30

30. Right of minorities to establish and administer educational institutions
(1) All minorities, whether based on religion or language, shall have the right to establish and administer educational institutions of their choice

WHAT ABOUT CONSTITUTIONAL PROVISIONS?

- 1 Articles 29 and 30 of the Constitution guarantees certain rights to minorities for protection of their culture, script and languages.
- 2 The Constitution has not defined or identified religious and linguistic minorities.

WHAT DO YOU UNDERSTAND BY MINORITY STATUS?



WHAT ABOUT CONSTITUTIONAL PROVISIONS?

- 3** The question of who will determine which group is a minority came into focus and settled by the Supreme Court in *T.M.A.Pai Foundation & Ors vs State Of Karnataka*.
- 4** The Supreme Court held that the unit for the purpose of determining the definition of minority would be the state, not the whole of India.

WHAT DO YOU UNDERSTAND BY MINORITY STATUS?

WHAT HAPPENED SUBSEQUENTLY?

- 1** Minorities Commission was setup and it was envisaged to ensure minorities are able to enjoy the safeguards provided for them in the Constitution and various Central and State laws.
- 2** The National Commission for Minorities Act, was passed in 1992 to give statutory backing to the Commission.
- 3** It is applicable to whole of India except J&K.
- 4** It was defined minority as a community notified as such by the Central Govt. Using the power, the Central Govt. through Gazette notification in 1993 notified Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists and Zoroastrians (Parsis) as minorities for the purpose of this Act.
- 5** In 2014, Jains were included in the minorities.

4 The appeasement of none

We must move beyond the minority-majority binary



GOPAL KRISHNA AGARWAL

Communal politics, which ironically passes for secularism in this country, has been the bane of Indian politics. It can be traced back to the British policy of 'divide and rule', the result of which was Partition. The Constitution was a repudiation of these ideas and the politics that perpetuated them. It rejected the suggestions for a separate electorate for the minorities and the proportional representation system, which it felt would lead to a perpetually enervated nation. But in most policies that have been followed until now, we have seen furtherance of vote-bank politics. The narrative has to change.

The recent PIL filed by a Jammu-based advocate, Ankur Sharma, in the Supreme Court, alleging that the rights of religious and linguistic minorities in the State are being "siphoned off illegally and arbitrarily" and the subsequent affidavits by the Central and Jammu and Kashmir governments give us a chance to look again into the secularism versus communalism debate.

Defining minority

While Articles 29 and 30 of the Constitution guarantee certain rights to minorities for protection of their culture, script, and languages, the Constitution has not defined or identified religious and linguistic minorities. The question of who will determine which group is a minority was also left unanswered until the Supreme Court settled this in *TMA Pai Foundation v. State of Karnataka*,

Hindus are a religious minority in seven States (Arunachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Punjab) and in one UT (Lakshadweep). In J&K, Hindus have been at the receiving end of majoritarian wrath, and the constitutional guarantee of liberty of thought, expression, belief, faith and worship is being violated there. The status of West Pakistan refugees, who had migrated there at the time of Partition, is also relevant. Reports suggest that there are about 2.5 lakh Hindus. They are not recognised as state subjects and are denied the most basic human rights.

Though the Act nowhere makes it mandatory for States to have a Minorities Commission of their own, 18 do. However, the question is whether minorities get the benefits of being so in all the States where they are in minority. In Punjab, for instance, Hindus are only 38.4% of the population, but they have not been notified as a minority in the Punjab State Commission for Minorities Act, 2012. Is it not amoral to insist on special dispensation for minorities and deny Hindus minority status where they are entitled to it, as is being done by various political parties?



Furthering vote-bank politics

Further, the SC in *Bal Patil v. Union of India* had said the National and State Minorities Commissions should direct their activities to maintain the unity and integrity of India by

The goal is to go beyond minority-majority binary. To achieve this, all our policies must move beyond either majoritarianism or minoritarianism.

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